

**How can we not marvel at the cross,
which destroyed the might of death, and the descent into Hades!
The hymns of the 4th Sunday of Pascha, the Blind Man, Vespers**

VIDEO: <https://youtu.be/zTQ-qOJsaWk>

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We look at several of the hymns of Vespers and Lydia for the fourth Sunday of Pascha, when we commemorate the blind man. We can learn just about everything about our theology from our services.

Stichos 10: Bring my soul out of prison * that I may confess Thy name.

By Thy Cross hast Thou destroyed the might of death, * O Christ our Saviour, * and hast set at nought the deception of the devil. * And the human race, saved by faith, * ever offereth a hymn unto Thee.

Our conception of the cross is very different than the way it is perceived among other Christian confessions. When I was a Protestant, the whole idea of the cross was that Jesus died on the cross in place of us so that we would be judged, since He is infinitely capable of taking on all of our sins and making satisfaction for them. It always seemed very passive and incomplete to me and very strange that the son of God would have to be judged so that the father would cease from

being angry this so-called substitutional atonement does not exist in Orthodox thought.

For the Orthodox Christians, the cross is a symbol of victory, and it is the beginning of the destruction of death. We sing hundreds of times during the Paschal season: "Christ is risen from the dead, trampling down death by death" - the trampling down of death occurred immediately after Christ died on the cross and He went to Hades to destroy the

power of sin and death over us. He went to Hades in the fullness of his divinity and with his human soul. His human body was lying dead in a tomb but not suffering corruption.

The deception of the devil was overcome by Christ breaking the control that the devil has over us by causing us to become slaves to sin. With baptism, we become new creatures and we are, if you will, remade in the image of the Risen Christ so that we can become victorious over our sins.

If we were able to only say a few words about the cross, we would not say that “By

the cross we are forgiven,” but rather we would say that “By the cross Jesus Christ destroyed the might of death and set at naught the deception of the devil.”

If the might of death is destroyed, we are empowered to live righteously. The substitutionary atonement, so ubiquitous among almost anyone who purports to be Christian and is not Eastern Orthodox, only speaks of forgiveness and nothing about our being empowered to become perfect. For us, the cross empowers us to become perfect and does not just affect forgiveness.

Stichos 8: Out of the depths have I cried unto Thee, O Lord; * O Lord, hear my voice.

I glorify the power of the Father and the Son, * and I hymn the authority of the Spirit: * the indivisible and uncreated Godhead, * the consubstantial Trinity, * Who reigneth unto the ages of ages.

We selected this to sticheron because it's typical of thousands of hymns which speak of the Holy Trinity. The Trinity Acts in one essence, although we distinguish its three persons.

Knowing the holy Trinity is the purpose of our life. Therefore, it is good to sing of the One whom we long to know. There is power in worshiping the holy Trinity and not most often segmenting Him into one of the persons

of the holy Trinity, such as, for example ending a prayer: "in Jesus name."

We end our prayers almost always with an invocation of the Holy Trinity. we often begin our prayers with an invocation of the Holy Trinity. Because the Holy Trinity exists eternally, love is an eternal attribute of God and love is the greatest commandment, because by loving we become like God. So it is very useful to the soul to be continually invoking and praising the Holy Trinity

Stichos 7: Let Thine ears be attentive * to the voice of my supplication.

We bow down before Thy precious Cross, O Christ, * and we hymn and glorify Thy resurrection ; * for by Thy stripes have we all been healed.

We Orthodox Christians are absolutely aware that our Lord Jesus Christ suffered on the cross, that is, he had “stripes”. We theologize countless times in our hymns that these sufferings are for our healing and not just for some expiation of our sins. And we

bow down before the cross because the cross is a symbol of victory for us, and when we think of the cross we think of healing more than forgiveness. Healing incorporates forgiveness but not vice versa.

Stichos 5: For Thy name’s sake have I patiently waited for Thee, O Lord; my soul hath patiently waited for Thy word , * my soul hath hoped in the Lord. **Descending, Christ proclaimed the glad tidings * to those in hades , saying: * ‘Be of good cheer! Now have I triumphed! * I am the resurrection! * And, breaking down the gates of death, I will lead you Up!’**

When I became Orthodox this was a novel doctrine for me, but it is something that we speak of in almost every service and certainly many hundreds of times during the Paschal season. That is, that after the God man Jesus Christ’s death on the cross, that is when our Lord’s human body died, He went in the fullness of his divinity with his human soul to Hades and destroyed the power of sin and death over us.

This is why we associate the cross with victory. We believe as a dogmatic truth that the Lord descended into Hades and that all of the souls in Hades the righteous and the unrighteous those who have believed in the one God and those who had been pagan, everyone saw Jesus Christ and heard the preaching of the good news. And many, whose hearts were good, accepted this good news and were raised out of Hades so they are no longer imprisoned there.

Stichos 1: For He hath made His mercy to prevail over us, * and the truth of the Lord abideth forever.

Seeing Thee, the paralytic, * who was like an unburied corpse, cried out: * ‘Have mercy on me, O Lord, * for my bed hath become a coffin for me. * Of what profit is my life for me? * I have no need of the Sheep’s Pool, * for I never have anyone to cast me into it when the waters are troubled. * But I approach Thee, the Source of healings, * that with all I may cry Out to Thee: * O Lord, glory to Thee!’

The services are full of unspeakably beautiful poetry. The lifelong condition of the paralytic is captured very well by describing him as an "unburied corpse." This man was 38 years lying in a state of paralysis, wanting someone to help him but having no one. And then someone came, the God-man, Jesus Christ.

We should recognize that what the paralytic said to the Lord when he asked if he

wanted to be healed is something we also say to Him. And it is a sin. The paralytic only saw negatives. He didn't see the Lord standing before him and thought there was no one to help him, even though the God-man Jesus Christ was right in front of him!

If we are honest with ourselves sometimes we give this answer when the Lord says do you want to be healed.

Dogmatic Theotokion, in Tone III — How can we not marvel * at thy giving birth to the God-man, O all-honoured one. * For without having accepted the temptation of a man, O all-immaculate one, * without a father thou gavest birth in the flesh to a Son * Who was begotten without a mother before the ages, * without His undergoing change, confusion, or division, * yet preserving intact the character of both essences. * Wherefore, O Virgin Mother and Mistress, * entreat Him, that the souls of those who in Orthodox manner * confess thee to be the Theotokos be saved.

This sticheron poses a rhetorical question, but we should answer it! How can we not marvel? We can easily not Marvel at the beauty of the Trinity and of the Holiness of the Theotokos and the magnificence of her obedience and of the Holiness of the Saints and of anything else in the Orthodox faith if we are not living a strict and careful and intense interior life. It's actually very easy to not marvel at Holy things and to say holy things without being touched or moved in any way.

One of the reasons I love our services so much is because they continually speak of

holy things in a theological and very compunctionate and marvelous way. It's Up for us to us whether or not we are going to listen to those things and be moved in our hearts. If we're not listening with our hearts then it wouldn't matter if the choir was singing the hymn or reading out names from the phone book.

Our services continually contain poetry like this where we state that Jesus Christ is a person without a mother and without a father. Of course, He is without a mother, being the only begotten Son of God before all the ages, and He is without a father in that He

became man without the seed of a man through the virgin Mary. It's important to keep talking about things like this and keep praying things like this because they start to change us from the inside.

We use the terminology: "without change confusion or division" many times when we describe the interplay of the two Natures of Christ within the one person, the God man Jesus Christ. Our dogma is that Jesus Christ was and is God before the ages, and as God, he has never changed and never will change; however, He chose to become man, and as a man, he certainly changed. He went from a human being that is subject to death to one that is immortal and perfected. And in so doing he became a template for us, as the apostle Paul teaches: "Till we all come in the unity of the faith, and of the knowledge of the Son of God, unto a perfect man, unto the measure of the stature of the fulness of Christ: (14) That we henceforth be no more children, tossed to and fro, and carried about

with every wind of doctrine, by the sleight of men, and cunning craftiness, whereby they lie in wait to deceive; (15) But speaking the truth in love, may grow up into him in all things, which is the head, even Christ." (Ephesians 4:13-15 KJV)

We are subject to death because of our sins; our Lord Jesus Christ was subject to death because of His human flesh but he had no sins. Therefore He could defeat sin when He died and make it possible for us to defeat sin.

There is a reason why there are many heresies regarding the person Jesus Christ. If we do not understand who Jesus Christ is we do not understand who we are to become. He is fully human and fully God and his two Natures are united to one another but not mixed because if you mixed something with God then the created would become part of the uncreated which is of course an oxymoron.

Stichera at the Litya

Doxasticon for the Paralytic, in Tone V — At the Sheep's Pool a man lay infirm; * and seeing Thee, O Lord, he cried out: * 'I have no man who, when the water is troubled, will cast me therein. * When I come, another goeth in before me and receiveth the healing, * and I lie here in mine infirmity.' * And straightway, having mercy, the Saviour said to him: * 'It is for thy sake that I became a man, * for thy sake I clothed Myself in flesh, * and thou sayest: I have no man. * Take up thy bed and walk.' * All things are possible for Thee, * all things obey Thee, all things submit to Thee. * O Holy One, remember us all * and have mercy, in that Thou lovest mankind.

This sticheron is interesting in that it is a dialogue that did not actually occur but could have occurred, and then a commentary on that dialogue.

Of course, the paralytic did answer Christ that he had no man to help him when Christ asked if he wanted to be healed. That's a strange answer to a question from someone who's capable of healing him standing right in front of him! Christ did not engage the man in further conversation but only told him to get up and carry his bed and walk, and of course the man was immediately healed.

It is clear that his faith was weak but Christ did not require of him great faith for the healing. This should give us great hope. But what if Christ had engaged in more conversation? The extra dialogue before he healed the man reminds me of the parable of the good Samaritan. In that parable, two men passed by on the other side of the wounded man who was dying from his sins because they wouldn't be able to help him in any case. But the Good Samaritan purposefully traveled to the man. He came directly to him and He comes directly to all of us.

So the Lord says in this hypothetical dialogue: "It is for thy sake that I became a man, * for thy sake I clothed Myself in flesh, * and thou sayest: I have no man." When we are despondent, we are basically answering the Lord's question with the same answer as the paralytic, that we have no man. It would behoove us to understand that the Lord has come directly to each one of us and that we always have a "man", that is the God-Man Jesus Christ.

the commentary following this theoretical conversation is: "All things are possible for Thee, * all things obey Thee, all things submit to Thee. * O Holy One, remember us all * and have mercy, in that Thou lovest mankind."

You could easily copy this out as a prayer and say it every day and be profited very greatly from it. Much of what we do is a battle against our unbelief and it is good to always say affirmations of who Jesus is to battle against that unbelief.